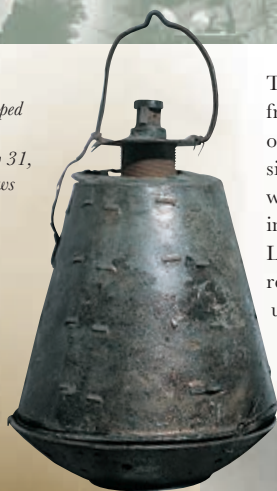


AIRSHIP FIRE BOMB

This incendiary bomb was dropped by Zeppelin LZ 38 in the first airship raid on London, on May 31, 1915. The German airship crews initially dropped fire bombs by hand over the side of their gondola; automatic release mechanisms were added later. The incendiary bombs of the time were too small, unreliable, and easily extinguished to have much destructive effect.



The sporadic arrival of airships over Britain from 1915 onward made a deep impression on the civilian population. None who heard the sinister thumping of the Maybach engines or witnessed the dark silhouette passing overhead in the night ever forgot the experience. A Londoner who was a child at the time later remembered having been “conscious of an unspoken fear around me... as I watched those sinister shapes slipping in and out of the searchlight beams.” Yet airship commanders

found mounting a sustained bombing campaign beyond their capabilities. Even before effective air defenses were in place, flying from a base in north Germany or occupied Belgium to Britain and back in pitch darkness was an awesome challenge. Once the British deployed night-flying aircraft and ground batteries armed with incendiary ammunition, traveling to London under a vast bag of inflammable gas began to seem like a very bad idea.

Aerial sailors

A fundamental limiting factor on airship operations was weather. Heavy cloud, strong winds, or storms made missions impossible. Yet when they set off, the airship commanders had

**NAVAL PATROL**

This rare photograph (left) shows German naval airships in flight. Naval airship crews spent much of the war on patrol over the North Sea. Although their usefulness was limited by the inability to operate in bad weather, airships were more effective on these reconnaissance missions at sea than in their role as a strategic bombing force.

PUTTING OUT FIRES

Firemen douse rubble on the morning after a Zeppelin air-raid on London in 1917. Kaiser Wilhelm II initially refused to allow the bombing of cities, but then permitted it with the proviso that residential areas and cultural monuments should be spared. In 1915, a further amendment allowed the bombing of any part of London. In practice, airship commanders had little control over where their bombs landed. Bombing cities meant killing civilians.

